

Union division under Brigadier General Philip Sheridan seized control of a creek in fierce fighting early on October 8, the men strongly motivated by thirst. Bragg was slow to realize that a major battle was beginning, but returned to assume command in the late morning.

On the afternoon of October 8, a daring Confederate assault almost routed the Union left, but the Union right pushed into Perryville's streets. When darkness fell, Bragg prudently withdrew his forces, which would have faced superior Union numbers if combat had resumed the following day.

Bragg, at last, joined up with Smith, and the two Confederate commanders hotly debated their next move. Neither Bragg's nor Smith's forces had the strength in numbers or the logistical organization to keep a hold on the state of Kentucky once a Northern counteroffensive got underway. Controversially, Bragg decided to abandon the invasion and pull back to Tennessee. With the almost simultaneous defeat of a Confederate army under Major General Earl Van Dorn at the Second Battle of Corinth, and Lee's withdrawal from Maryland after the Battle of Antietam, the picture for the Confederacy looked bleak.



Confederate retreat after Perryville

This section from William Travis's panorama shows the battered but triumphant Union forces in the foreground, Bragg in retreat in the distance. Travis shadowed the Army of the Cumberland, often sketching on site.